

SHOWCASE

MATCHLOCK MUSKET

In the late 16th century, the harquebus (see p.20) developed into a type of matchlock musket that was widely adopted in western Europe. Matchlocks were more unwieldy and unreliable than the wheel-lock guns invented soon afterward (see p.27), but they continued to be popular until the end of the 17th century, largely due to their simplicity.

MATCHLOCK MUSKET**Date** c. mid-17th century**Origin** Britain**Barrel** 49½in (126cm)**Caliber** .75in (19mm)

Comb of stock assists
in bringing shoulder
to axis of recoil

Trigger

Trigger
guardCurled arm
of restNozzle without
measuring device

▲ MATCHLOCK MUSKET

While the matchlock musket was a significant improvement over the hand-cannon, it was still a very clumsy weapon. Even in dry weather the match could be extinguished all too easily, and its glowing end was a giveaway at night. The best models were, however, surprisingly accurate and were capable of killing a man at 109 yards (100m) or more.

Sling is
decorative
as well as
functional

◀ POWDER FLASK

This flask is made of wood, covered in fabric, and has an outer iron frame. Originally its nozzle would have had a thumb-operated shutter at its base, which was used to measure the individual charges of gunpowder for a musket.

▼ MUSKET REST

The earliest military matchlocks were very heavy and required the use of a rest. The rest itself had to be of sturdy design, and this increased the gunner's load. By about 1650, guns had become light enough that rests were no longer needed.

Socket for
wooden staff

FULL VIEW